the hands of Chinese troops that had infiltrated ahead. After the collapse at Sela, the demoralized Indian forces offered only token resistance at Dirang Zong and Bomdila and the Chinese forces advanced unopposed towards the plains of Assam. By 19 November the Chinese troops had reached Chako, just 120km from Tezpur in North Assam.

In the western sector, the first phase of the Chinese attack commenced on 20 October. Thinly spread, the Indian posts in this sector were soon isolated and destroyed. Indian forces fought hard to hold the Rezang La Ridge, in order to prevent a nearby airstrip at Daulat Beg Oldi from being seized. By 28 October, Chinese forces had captured about 1,900 square kilometres of Indian territory. After realizing the magnitude of the attack, the Indian Army withdrew many of the isolated outposts to the south-east.

The Chinese offensive resumed on 17 November near Chushul, followed by attacks on Gurung Hill and Rezang La, which was held by a company of 13 KUMAON. Although their first attack against Rezang La failed, the Chinese renewed their efforts and captured the post after fierce hand-to-hand fighting, but 13 KUMAON had succeeded in stalling the Chinese advance and had saved Chushul airfield.

On 19 November, China declared a ceasefire as it had reached its claim line. While this was a humiliating defeat for India, it spurred a modernization and expansion drive that stood the Indian Army in good stead in the wars to come.